

WHAT WORKS IN THEIR FAVOUR



SUPRIYA SULE

- Public sympathy for father Sharad Pawar following Ajit's rebellion and the fracture in the NCP
- Anti-incumbency against the ruling BJP and Maharashtra's Mahayuti grand alliance
- Optics of extended Pawar family, including Ajit's younger brother Shrinivas, closing ranks with Sharad Pawar

SUNETRA PAWAR

- Ajit Pawar's ground connect. The NCP leader is said to have the support of most local leaders
- NCP and ally BJP holding four of the six assembly segments in the constituency
- Ajit's better booth-level management, proven while handling past campaigns for Supriya and Sharad Pawar

a BJP leader. A second BJP leader, however, admits, that "there is sympathy for Pawar, as he is being compelled to fight this battle at his age. Even some BJP workers and their families were being swayed by this rhetoric... I am asking my workers how it affects them if the Pawar family is vivisected into two," he says. Adds a senior Congress leader, "Voters usually go with a leader or are swayed by an emotional wave", hinting at the edge this gives Sule.

Perhaps mindful of the undercurrent of sympathy for the senior Pawar, leaders of the Mahayuti are trying to present the Baramati battle as one between Modi and senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and not between Sharad and Ajit Pawar. Speaking in a public meeting in Pune before Sunetra filed her nomination on April 18, Ajit too said that this was not an "election in a village or among the extended family, but one that would determine the fate of the country". Without naming Pawar or Sule, he blamed his opponents for trying to give the contest an emotional twist. "This is not a battle between Pawar *saheb* and *dada* or Sunetra *tai* versus Supriya *tai*... it is an election which will determine if the MP of Baramati stands by Modiji or Rahul Gandhi," added Maharashtra deputy chief minister and BJP leader Devendra Fadnavis.

Building Bridges

The stiff competition has forced both sides to find new allies and mend fences with old rivals. Both Pawar and Sunetra have visited their old political foe and veteran Congress leader Anantrao Thopte, whose son Sangram is a Congress MLA from Bhor. Pawar also visited his former classmate and aide-turned-critic Chandrarao a.k.a. Chandraanna Taware and tried to get influential clans, like the Kakades, on his side.

Ajit, meanwhile, has managed to contain a brewing rebellion by Shiv Sena leader and former minister Vijay Shivtare, who had threatened to contest as an independent from Baramati, and got adversaries like former minister Harshvardhan Patil on his side. The Mahayuti has also wooed former minister Mahadeo Jankar from the Rashtriya Samaj Paksha (RSP), whose vote bank includes the Dhangars (shepherds), who form a substantial section of voters in Baramati, Indapur, Daund, and parts of Purandar. Jankar is contesting from Parbhani from the NCP's quota. In 2014, Jankar had contested from Baramati against Sule as a BJP ally, and the Modi wave coupled with a Dhangar consolidation ensured that Sule won by a slim margin of just under 70,000 votes. Sunetra and Ajit have also reached out to the BJP and Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) cadre; Ajit's maternal family has strong Sangh connections. What also works in Sunetra's favour is that sections of the Baramati Lok Sabha constituency, like Khadakwasla, Bhor and Purandar, are part of the fast-expanding urban agglomeration of Pune, and voters in these cosmopolitan and middle-class areas, said to comprise around 750,000 of the over 2.3 million electorate in the constituency, usually prefer to go with a national party like the BJP. However, while Sunetra enjoys the support of most local leaders in the area, the alleged bad blood and competition between these leaders could complicate things for her, making it difficult for them to work together cohesively, say sources.

According to a senior journalist who has extensively covered the Pawars, the outcome in Baramati will have far-reaching implications, with the politics of one of the two Pawars suffering a massive setback. "They (the people of Baramati) will determine the fate of the two factions of the NCP. They will decide whose leadership—Sharad Pawar's or Ajit's—prevails," he says. "Sunetra's defeat will affect Ajit's bargaining power with the BJP and may lead to some of his former MLAs returning to Pawar. If Sule loses, it will be a huge setback for Pawar in his twilight years...the biggest defeat of his political career." An NCP source, however, claims that despite the current tensions, and regardless of who wins or loses Baramati, the Pawar family factions will eventually accommodate each other. This, he said, was because their interests were intertwined in the many cooperatives and institutions in the state that the family controls. "Eventually, a Pawar will be the MP of Baramati," the source sums up. The outcome of the general election won't change that reality. ■